

PRODUCT-MARKET FIT & COMPETITIVE BRIEF

The desert is wide open.

Where the fit is strongest, where the global leaders are weakest, and the sharpest wedge to win it. Fight worldwide head-on and you lose a knife fight; win **MENA** first — where in the desert they're barely trying — then expand.

PMF isn't decided in a document. It's measured.

Gustaf Alstromer's whole point: product-market fit is not something you argue on a slide — it's something real users prove. The cleanest test in the industry is a single question.

*"How would you feel if you could **no longer** use this product?"*

PMF $\approx$ when $\geq 40\%$ say "very disappointed." (Sean Ellis test, used across YC.)

THE THREE WORDS IN THE QUOTE YOU SENT, MADE TESTABLE

ALSTROMER'S WORDS	THE REAL TEST	WHERE YOU STAND
genuinely want it	Pull from a specific segment	Unproven
willing to pay	Revenue, not signups	Unproven
would miss it	The 40% "very disappointed"	Unproven

Honest headline: **you don't have PMF yet — nobody does before users.**

What you *can* do now is pick the market where the fit hypothesis is strongest and incumbents weakest, ship to a narrow segment, and run the 40% test.

BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

Win MENA first, then expand.

Fighting **worldwide** head-on against AllTrails + Gaia + onX + Wikiloc is a knife fight you'll probably lose. **MENA is wide open** — the global leaders barely serve it. That's where "a gazillion times better than Gaia & Wikiloc" is actually achievable, because in the desert they're not really trying.

PMF scorecard — MENA vs. worldwide.

Scored 1–5 on how strong the *fit hypothesis* is — higher means a better opening for you.
Same product, two very different battlefields.

PMF DIMENSION	MENA (GCC-LED)	WORLDWIDE	WHY
Market pull / "want"	5	3	Dune bashing (<i>tatees</i> / تطعيس) is a deep cultural pastime in Saudi & UAE; worldwide demand is already well-served
Willingness to pay	5	3	GCC ~91% smartphone (UAE ~98%), high disposable income, premium-SUV culture; worldwide is price-sensitive & sub-fatigued
Incumbent weakness	5	2	No dominant localized off-road app in MENA; weak/no Arabic. Worldwide is saturated by 4 strong players
"Would miss it" hook	5	3	Desert = no signal + real risk → offline + SOS become can't-live-without; worldwide hikers have softer stakes
Cost to win the segment	4	1	A focused Saudi/UAE-club beachhead is reachable; worldwide CAC against AllTrails/Gaia is brutal
Differentiation headroom	5	3	AI + Arabic + desert-specific + safety is clearly new in MENA; worldwide your edges are narrower
Total (of 30)	29	17	MENA is the beachhead; worldwide is the eventual market

FIT-HYPOTHESIS SCORE, OF 30

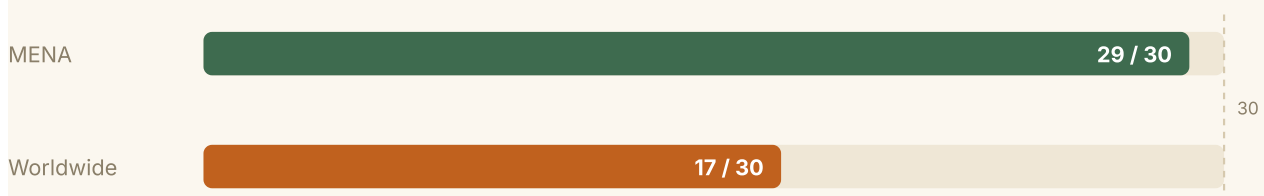


Fig. 1 — Same app, two battlefields. MENA scores nearly double on fit-hypothesis strength.

VERDICT

MENA is your PMF beachhead. Worldwide is your *eventual* market, entered later via a sharp niche (AI planning + safety for overlanding), not a frontal assault.

A smaller pie — but nobody's eating it.

Worldwide is the bigger pie, already sliced. MENA is smaller in absolute dollars but structurally under-served and rich — the ideal asymmetric bet.

SEGMENT	SIZE / TREND	NOTE
Global on/off-road navigation app market	~\$15–22B (2025), CAGR ~5–12%	The category you compete in
Global off-road vehicle market	~\$22.5B (2025) → \$35.9B (2033)	Your users' hardware spend — they invest heavily
MEA off-road vehicle market	~\$450M (2025), CAGR 5.7%	Smaller in \$ but fast & under-digitized
Middle East SUV market	~\$87.1B (2024)	The wallet behind the activity is enormous
GCC smartphone penetration	~91% (UAE ~98%), internet ~99%	Distribution is not a barrier

~98%

UAE SMARTPHONE PENETRATION

\$87B

MIDDLE EAST SUV MARKET

Under-digitized

NO LOCALIZED OFF-ROAD LEADER IN MENA

Strong worldwide. Absent in the sand.

Pricing is 2025–2026 and shifts often; treat as directional.

POWER-USER INCUMBENT

Gaia GPS

Free · Premium ~\$39.99/yr · +Outside+ \$89.99/yr

NAILS 300+ map overlays, deep topo, flexible offline, expert route-building.

GAP #1 complaint: offline downloads buggy & slow; app gone bloated. Uncurated DB, steep for beginners, weak Arabic / no MENA focus.

GLOBAL COMMUNITY LIBRARY

Wikiloc

Freemium · Premium €19.99/yr · 14-day trial

NAILS 60M community trails, 80+ activities, global coverage, cheap.

GAP GPS/distance inaccuracy, tracks drawn as straight lines, Android GPS-lock failures, dated UX, hiking/cycling-centric — not built for 4×4/dune.

OFF-ROAD SPECIALIST (US-CENTRIC)

onX Offroad

Free · Premium \$34.99/yr · Elite \$99.99/yr

NAILS curated trails with open/closed status, great onboarding, land-ownership data.

GAP very US-centric, fewer map layers than Gaia, little MENA presence.

WORLDWIDE CATEGORY KING

AllTrails

60M+ users · 450k trails · 200+ countries · 4.9★

NAILS brand, SEO, community, polished UX, huge top-of-funnel.

GAP hiking-first, not off-road/overlanding; generic; not desert/4×4 specialized; weak Arabic & MENA depth.

THE PATTERN

Every one of them is strong on maps and worldwide scale — and every one is thin on Arabic, desert-specific intelligence, group safety, and off-grid. That thin column is your entire opening.

Where you win, where you don't.

✓ strong ● partial / weak ✗ absent. Lead with the starred rows; don't fight where the incumbents already win.

CAPABILITY	YOUR APP	GAIA	WIKILOC	ONX	ALLTRAILS
AI trip planning (conversational, conditions-aware) ★	✓	✗	✗	✗	●
Off-road / 4×4-specific design	✓	●	✗	✓	✗
Desert / dune-specific intelligence ★	✓	✗	✗	●	✗
Live weather on planning surface	✓	●	✗	●	●
Built-in safety / SOS (plus-codes, share, check-in) ★	✓	●	✗	●	●
Offline maps	●→✓	✓ buggy	●	✓	✓
Community / UGC trails	✓	●	✓	✓	✓
Track recorder → shareable trail	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Arabic-first / MENA localization ★	✓	✗	●	✗	●
Convoy / group live tracking ★	✓	✗	✗	●	✗
Modern, fast, un-bloated UX	✓	✗	●	✓	✓
Map-layer depth (topo overlays)	●	✓	●	●	●
Global trail database scale	●	●	✓	●	✓

★ = your differentiators to lead with (build/finish & market hard). The last two rows — map-layer depth and raw trail-DB scale — are where incumbents beat you. Don't fight there first.

Start from the alternatives, not the features.

Positioning is relative. Define yourself against what a Gulf off-roader actually does today — then the value becomes obvious.

- 1 **Competitive alternatives.** Gaia (English, generic), Maps.me/OsmAnd (offline but dumb), WhatsApp groups + a guide's tribal knowledge, or *nothing* — just follow a friend who "knows the dunes."
- 2 **Unique attributes.** AI planning · Arabic-first · desert/dune guidance · integrated safety/SOS + convoy tracking · one modern app instead of three clunky ones.
- 3 **Value delivered.** Plan a safe desert run in minutes, not hours of forum-digging; don't get lost or stranded with no signal; bring the family/club safely.
- 4 **Best-fit beachhead.** GCC weekend off-roaders & 4×4 clubs — Saudi (Zulfi, Riyadh) and UAE (Liwa, Al Qudra). 25–45, premium SUV, social, safety-conscious, pays for apps.

5 · THE CATEGORY YOU WIN

The AI desert-adventure & safety companion for the Gulf.

Not "another trail app." Own a category the incumbents don't even contest — and you're first.

Where to actually win.

Two wedges, in order. One is an empty category you can own now; the other is a narrow worldwide entry for later.

DO THIS FIRST

MENA wedge

No incumbent is **Arabic-first** or **desert-specialized** → an empty category is yours to own.

Safety is the killer hook. Desert = zero signal + real danger. Offline + SOS + convoy + check-in becomes the thing people are *very disappointed* to lose — your 40% test.

Off-roading is social in the Gulf (clubs, family outings) → group/convoy features create network effects the solo-hiker apps ignore.

LATER

Worldwide wedge

AI planning + safety for the **overlanding** niche — where Gaia is bloated and AllTrails is hiking-only.

Enter narrow, not broad. A sharp niche you can defend beats a frontal assault on four entrenched players.

Sequence matters: worldwide only *after* MENA PMF is proven with the 40% test.

*Own the empty category first. **Arabic-first, desert-specific, group-safety off-grid** — the one place the giants aren't looking.*

Concrete moves.

Ranked by impact-to-effort. The first three are the wedge; the rest widen the moat.

- 1 Own desert safety.** Offline-first SOS with plus-codes, live location share, group/convoy tracking, "tell someone before you go" check-in, recovery-point intelligence, live **off-camber & rollover-risk alerts** from the vehicle's tilt, and community **"heads-up" hazard waypoints** — soft drop-offs, sabkha/salt-bog, sharp rock, washouts, fence lines, camel crossings — kept trustworthy with community "still there?" confirms + expiry, and approved-marshall reports weighted highest.

This is the "would die without it" feature Gaia & Wikiloc simply don't have.
- 2 AI planning that's conditions-aware — and terrain-aware for beginners & families.** "Plan me a 3-hour intermediate dune run near Liwa this weekend, family-safe, back before sunset" → real route + weather + difficulty + safety brief. Use terrain elevation to grade difficulty and steer first-timers and family campers to the gentlest option — low, firm, flat ground near access points.

Caveat: raw elevation ≠ dune difficulty — public data (~30 m) misses individual dunes and dunes shift, so derive slope/ruggedness and blend with community difficulty tags, not elevation alone. Deterministic use of **known** terrain data — not the hazard "prediction" we deliberately avoid.

Data strategy: ship a free **Copernicus GLO-30 (~30 m)** baseline for slope grading now and let community drives refine it — never promise centimetre-accurate dunes. How we *source, build and 3D-render* that terrain is a play in its own right — see §8.
- 3 Arabic-first + local.** Full RTL Arabic UI, local place names, SAR/AED pricing, local club partnerships. The incumbents treat Arabic as an afterthought.
- 4 Fix the thing Gaia users hate most: offline downloads.** Make offline bulletproof and obvious — Gaia's #1 review complaint. Beating them on *their* core feature is free credibility.
- 5 Desert/dune-specific intelligence** Gaia/Wikiloc lack: sand conditions, dune difficulty grading, tire-pressure guidance, sunset/heat windows. Let approved UAE club marshals contribute knowledge — text, voice, photo, video, guided Q&A — as verified, trusted input.

Mechanism: curate contributions into a searchable knowledge base the AI **retrieves** from, with marshal-verified entries weighted highest — not naïve auto-fine-tuning, which invites hallucination. Process voice/photo/video async in the cloud. This "approved marshal" trust layer is both quality control **and** the community moat competitors can't copy.
- 6 Modern, fast, un-bloated UX** (your 4-theme system is already a brand asset) vs. Gaia's "buggy/bloated" reputation and Wikiloc's straight-line-track bugs.
- 7 Community with quality**, not Wikiloc's uneven dump — verified/curated local trails + your recorder turning real runs into trusted routes.

Map the desert as it's actually driven.

Every recorded drive is a sensor pass. The recorder already logs position, altitude, speed & heading every second — add the phone's barometer and motion sensors and each run also captures the **grade and camber** of the ground. Enough runs and you've mapped the terrain in 3D — and captured what no off-the-shelf elevation model can: *how it actually drives*.

- 1 **Two signals, one mounted phone.** **Elevation:** GPS altitude is rough ($\pm 10\text{--}20$ m); the **barometric altimeter** in most modern phones gives sub-metre *relative* precision → a clean up-and-down profile along the driven line. **Attitude:** the accelerometer + gyroscope give **pitch** (climb grade) and **roll** (off-camber), cleanest at steady speed with the two sensors fused and filtered to reject bumps and braking.
- 2 **Calibrate once per mount, on level ground.** Phone fixed vertically in a holder → one "park on flat ground, tap to zero" step learns the mount angle; from then on *phone reading – zero = vehicle attitude*, no re-calibration unless it's re-seated.

On your questions: the phone's own sensors **are** the spirit level — when still they read tilt to a fraction of a degree, better than a photo ever could, so don't gate calibration on a photo (keep it optional, as a marshal "here's my mount" trust shot). And no — without that zero the phone knows its **own** tilt vs gravity but not the **mount offset**, so it can't just assume it's level; the level-ground tap supplies the reference. It *can*, though, auto-detect a stationary, flat-looking moment and prompt "*looks flat — calibrate now?*"
- 3 **Seed with marshals & advanced drivers first.** They'll actually follow the mount-and-calibrate protocol, so their runs become high-quality seed data — weighted highest via the same "approved marshal" trust layer. Widen to advanced drivers, then everyone; the crowd averages out noise over popular lines. One track is noisy — 500 passes over the same dune are accurate.
- 4 **The payoff: a rotatable 3D relief of every trail.** The driven line draped over a terrain mesh, coloured by grade and camber — not a literal hologram, but a 3D model you can spin (it fits the 3D map you're already building). And off-camber angle doubles as a **live safety signal**: "*off-camber 22° ahead*" is a rollover warning no trail app has.
- 5 **Buy a stable baseline; let the crowd keep the dunes fresh.** You're not drunk — hyper-detailed data exists.

Free (~30 m): Copernicus GLO-30, SRTM, ALOS AW3D30 — fine for general relief now. **Commercial high-res:** Airbus **WorldDEM Neo (~5 m)** + Pléiades Neo imagery (~30 cm); **ALOS AW3D** (5 m → 0.5 m); Maxar WorldView (~30 cm); Intermap — sold per km², licence-restricted. **UAE-specific:** Bayanat / **Space42** and **MBRSC** (KhalifaSat) hold national high-res Earth-observation data — a purchase or partnership could seed the whole country and be a credibility/BD win. **The catch that makes crowd-refresh the moat:** dunes migrate metres a year, so a survey-grade *dune* map goes stale — buy high-res for the **stable** terrain (Hajar Mountains, wadis, rock trails) + a few flagship dune "playgrounds," and let phones continuously refresh the shifting sand.

*Don't pay to survey what the desert rewrites every season — **buy the mountains, crowdsource the sand.***

Don't underprice the Gulf.

The GCC tolerates premium pricing and off-roading is a group activity — so a family/convoy plan lifts ARPU above what solo-hiker apps ever reach. Sell on *safety*, not map count.

DIRECTIONAL TIER STRUCTURE (LOCALIZE SAR/AED)

TIER	PRICE	GATES
Free	\$0	Discovery, browse, community uploads — seeds the trail DB (cold-start fix)
Pro	~\$39–49/yr	Offline, SOS, AI planning, desert intelligence
Family / Convoy	premium	Multi-vehicle live tracking, shared safety — higher ARPU

WHY A SAFETY TIER

Safety converts willingness-to-pay better than maps do. A "Safety" tier justifies a premium people will actually pay for — the map count never will.

Generous free tier for discovery + community uploads, gate offline/SOS/AI behind paid. **Worldwide later:** match AllTrails/Gaia (~\$35.99–39.99/yr) but sell on AI + safety, not layers.

Where incumbents still beat you.

Everything above is a hypothesis until users prove it. Here's where you're genuinely exposed — and how to blunt each one.

RISK	WHY IT BITES	MITIGATION
Map-layer depth & global scale	Gaia/Wikiloc/AllTrails have years of data you can't match early	Don't compete here — lean on AI + safety + local
Cold-start	A community app with no community is empty	Curated MENA trails + club seeding <i>before</i> opening UGC
Offline reliability is hard	But it's table-stakes in the desert	Budget real engineering — it's also your wedge vs Gaia
PMF is still unproven	Everything here is a hypothesis	Validate with the 40% test before scaling spend

THE DISCIPLINE

Resist the urge to go worldwide or build map-layer parity. Your only job right now is to make one MENA segment *very disappointed* to lose you.

Find PMF in one desert first.

Depth over breadth. Pick one beachhead, make it undeniable there, run the number, and only then pour fuel on it.

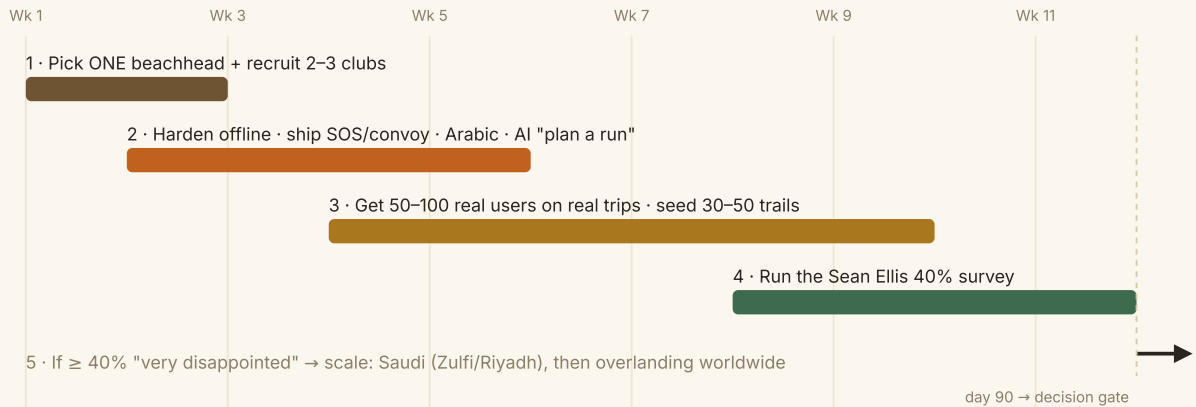


Fig. 2 — Twelve weeks to a real PMF signal. The survey at day 90 is the gate: below 40%, iterate the wedge; at or above, scale.

THE GATE

If $< 40\%$ say "very disappointed," don't scale — interview the not-disappointed and sharpen the wedge. If $\geq 40\%$ in MENA, *then* pour fuel on it.

APPENDIX

Sources & caveats.

Gaia GPS — gaiagps.com/membership · help.gaiagps.com · Trustpilot & App Store reviews · justuseapp.com

Wikiloc — wikiloc.com/premium (16M users / 60M trails) · worldsapps.com · justuseapp.com · appgrooves.com

onX Offroad — onxmaps.com/offroad/app/pricing · **AllTrails** — time.com (TIME100 2026) · similarweb.com/website/alltrails.com

Market sizing — dataintelo.com · cognitivemarketresearch.com · verifiedmarketreports.com · kenresearch.com

MENA off-road culture — thenationalnews.com · arabnews.com (Zulfi *tatees*) · hidmc.com (Liwa)

GCC penetration & WTP — GSMA Mobile Economy 2025 · RevenueCat State of Subscription Apps 2025

Elevation & terrain data — Copernicus GLO-30 (ESA) · SRTM (NASA) · ALOS AW3D30 / AW3D commercial (JAXA · RESTEC/NTT) · WorldDEM Neo & Pléiades Neo (Airbus) · WorldView (Maxar) · Intermap · Bayanat / Space42 & MBRSC KhalifaSat (UAE national EO)

Caveat: data current as of mid-2025–2026; competitor pricing and features change frequently. Re-verify before any go-to-market or fundraising use. Scores are fit-hypothesis judgments, not measured PMF — the 40% test is the only real proof.